problems we ran into during that first year or so contributed a lot to that pain down in my stomach.

I was ashamed for having an ulcer. I'd always regarded an ulcer as evidence of weakness, and now I had one.

I didn't want anybody to know about it and so I kept it a secret from everyone except the family. I certainly didn't want the press saying the Democrats had given me an ulcer. I watched my diet, avoided the inevitable fried chicken, took a daily dose of Maalox, and prayed the ulcer would go away. But as we continued to open drawers and find more problems, the ache in my stomach got worse.

A little over a year later, however, I reached for my bottle of Maalox one morning and something inside me said, "You don't need this anymore." So I put down the bottle and didn't take my medicine that morning. An hour or two later, I had an appointment with a man from Southern California who had a problem he wanted to discuss with the governor. As he was leaving my office, he turned around and said, "Governor, you might like to know that I'm part of a group of people who meet every day and pray for you."

I was taken aback by what he said, but thanked him and said I also put a lot of stock in the power of prayer. Later the same day, another person, this time a man from Northern California, came to see me about a different matter, and as he was leaving, a similar thing happened: He turned around and told me that he met with a group of people who prayed daily for me.

Not long after that, I went to the doctor for my regular checkup. He poked my stomach and did the usual battery of tests. When he was finished, he looked up at me and said it seemed I didn't have an ulcer anymore.

When more test results came in, he said there was no evidence that I had ever had an ulcer. The power of prayer? I don't know, but I'd prayed daily for relief and I can't forget that impulse I had to stop taking my medicine, and then